

10-Point Small Business Network Security Checklist

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SECTION 1: PERIMETER & NETWORK PROTECTION

1. Firewall & Routing Defense

- **Action:** Change all factory-default administrative credentials on your network router, gateway, or firewall. Disable remote management interfaces over the public Internet.
- **Why It Matters:** Hackers use automated scripts to scan the web for routers using generic default passwords like admin or password, granting them instant control over your office network.

2. Wi-Fi Isolation (Guest Networks)

- **Action:** Ensure your internal office network is locked with WPA3 encryption. Set up a completely isolated "Guest Wi-Fi" network using a separate VLAN for employee mobile phones, smart devices, and office visitors.
- **Why It Matters:** If a visitor's personal device contains malware and connects to your primary Wi-Fi network, that malware can spread across your network and infect internal servers or employee machines.

SECTION 2: ENDPOINT & USER ACCESS SECURITY

3. Proactive OS & Third-Party Patching

- **Action:** Enable automated daily security patches for operating systems (Windows Update / macOS Software Update) and frequently targeted third-party software like web browsers (Chrome, Edge, Safari).
- **Why It Matters:** Most cyberattacks exploit known security bugs that software developers have already fixed. Delaying patches leaves your machines open to known threats.

4. Managed Endpoint Detection & Antivirus

- **Action:** Deploy centralized, commercial-grade endpoint protection on every workstation. Ensure real-time monitoring definitions are updated automatically and cannot be modified or disabled by standard employees.
- **Why It Matters:** Standard, free consumer antivirus programs cannot defend against advanced, zero-day

ransomware tracking scripts that encrypt entire business drives in minutes.

5. Enforce Strong Passwords & Mandatory MFA

- **Action:** Enforce a minimum password policy of 12 complex characters. Turn on Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) across all company logins, prioritizing critical systems like corporate email, accounting portals, and remote access channels.
- **Why It Matters:** Password guessing accounts for over 80% of data breaches. Activating MFA blocks automated password-cracking attempts, even if a hacker accurately guesses an employee's password.